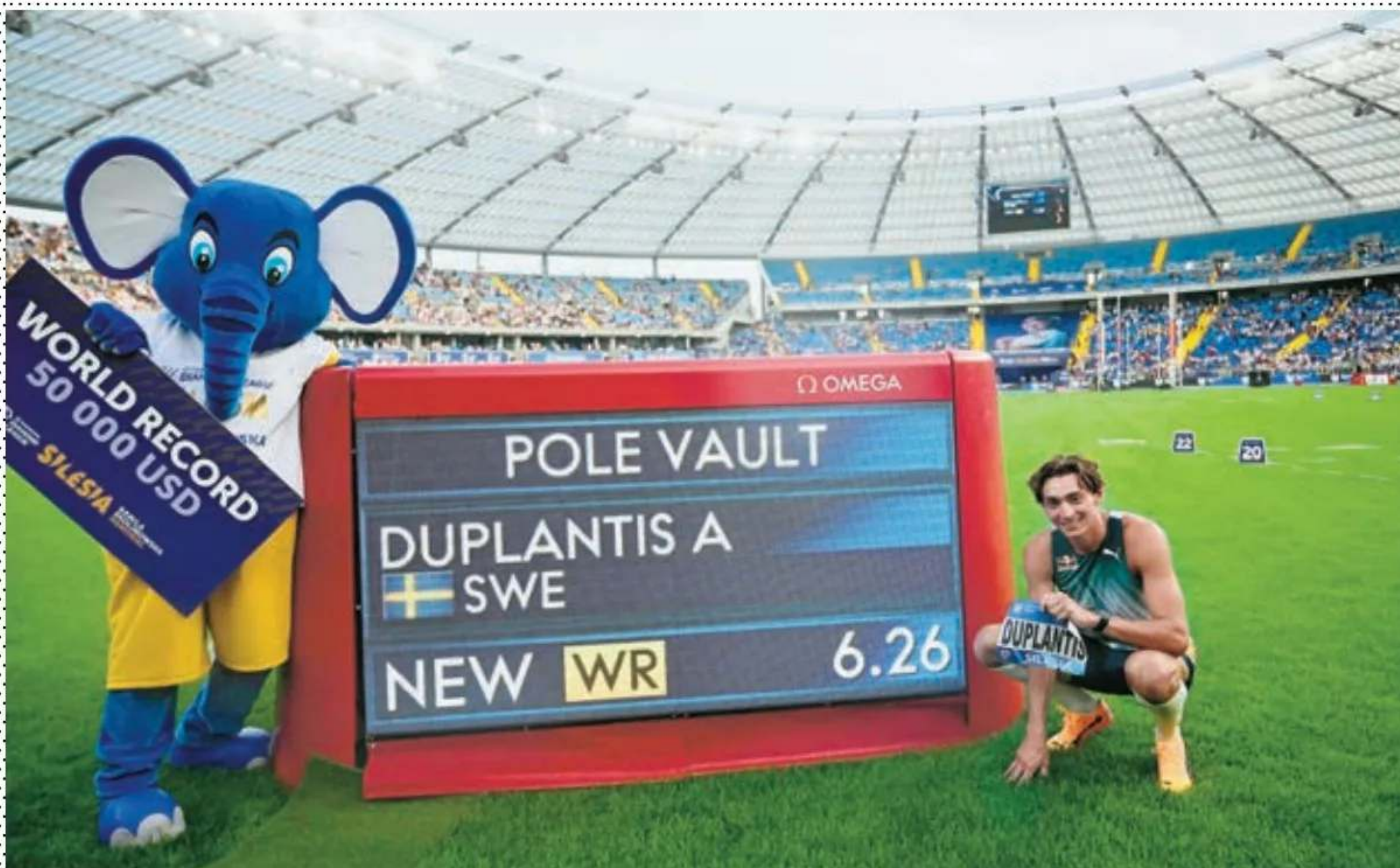




Smashing records: Armand 'Mondo' Duplantis cleared a height of 6.26 metres at the Silesia Diamond League meet to break the pole vault world record again. AFP

challenging events in track-and-field — relatively late in their development. That isn't true for Duplantis. The child of an elite jumper (Greg Duplantis had a PB of 5.80m) and an international heptathlete — Mondo — or Armand as he was originally named has been practising on the home-built pole vault pit in his family backyard in South Louisiana since the time he was six. Even though he's just 24, he already has the level of technical experience of someone many years older.

Duplantis was someone who was almost destined to be a pole vaulter. Speaking to *Athletics Weekly*, Scott Simpson, a former Olympic medal-winning coach, spoke of the jumper's almost manic obsession with the sport. "I've heard them (Mondo's parents) tell stories about having to go to his room and drag him off YouTube at midnight when

he was watching pole vault videos! He has had an obsession with it and that competitiveness, irrespective of what he's doing. That creates a mindset that is very difficult to beat. When he doesn't do as well as he would like, you can see that frustration in him, which is fascinating to watch," Simpson says.

And then there are the technical bits. At the Paris Olympics, American Sam Kendricks, who took silver in the pole vault, said Duplantis "had the hand of God behind him." He was referring to Duplantis's incredible speed on the runway, which allows him to put in incredible energy to bend the pole.

Kendricks isn't just speaking in hyperbole. As a schoolboy, Duplantis had a 100m personal best of 10.54 seconds, and in a couple of weeks he will be taking on 400m hurdles Olympic gold medallist Karsten Warholm in an exhibition 100m race.

"Mondo's speed on the runway is almost unprecedented," Simpson told *Athletics Weekly*. "The speed that he puts into the takeoff at the end of the approach run is higher than we have seen from anybody else previously. The more speed you

have, the higher the amount of energy you have available to you. Pole vault is an energy storage game. You store energy in the pole as it bends, and the more energy you can store in that pole, the more energy there is that can be returned to you to propel you into the air at the end of the jump," he said.

"In addition, the guys that have had good speed at takeoff typically don't complement it with on-pole technique, which is as good as the slower guys, but Mondo manages to do both. He puts a lot of speed through the take-off point but also has incredible on-pole abilities for the speed at which everything is happening — something that is quite unique to him. He is also so consistent. He has this huge toolbox that he has built up from doing pole vault from such a young age, which enables him to produce a really consistent output. Regardless of whether there's wind, rain, high pressure, a competitive environment, or him jumping on his own, it doesn't seem to matter because he still produces this incredible output and leaves him head and shoulders above everyone else," Simpson says.